Macbeth:
Manhood and Masculinity

high key ENGLISH

Key vocabulary

Match each word to the correct definition.

masculinity	to make two things equal to each other
emasculate	to make a man feel less male by taking away his power and confidence
gender norms	what a society deems as right and acceptable
mixed metaphor	ideas about how men and women should be and act
moral	a set of social characteristics that are associated with men
valiance	a combination of two or more incompatible metaphors
equate	bravery or determination, especially when things are difficult

What does masculinity mean to you?

Masculinity can mean different things to different people. Which do you agree with?

- ❏ Being courageous
- ❏ Being kind and empathetic towards others
- ❏ Having a close-knit family
- ❏ Being sensitive to others' feelings
- ❏ Nurturing and caring for a child
- ❏ Being physically strong and capable of handling heavy items
- ❏ Being open about your feelings
- ❏ Being ambitious and goal-oriented
- ❏ Being indecisive and easily influenced
- ❏ Being able to conceal your emotions in order to concentrate on what is most pragmatic
- ❏ Being fiercely loyal to friends or family
- ❏ Being able to defend yourself and fight if necessary
- ❏ Being physically aggressive
- ❏ Protecting women
- ❏ Having an innate sense of what is moral
- ❏ Being vulnerable in front of other people

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What is masculinity?

- ★ According to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, the term 'masculinity' has been around since **1571**, and is said to mean 'the assemblage of qualities regarded as characteristic of men; maleness, manliness'.
- ★ Our idea of 'manliness' has obviously changed since 1571. We now recognise that masculinity is a **socially constructed** set of ideas typically associated with men.
- ★ Women as well as men reinforce these social expectations of masculinity - for example, when Lady Macbeth tells her husband he's acting like a womanly coward.
- ★ Masculinity is often defined as the 'opposite' of femininity - male behaviours and female behaviours, in many societies, are kept **separate**.

Do you think 'masculinity' is a helpful word to use, or does it simply reinforce stereotypical gender norms?

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Jacobean views of masculinity

Men in the Jacobean era were generally expected to:

- ★ **Suppress** any displays of emotion - particularly those of fear, vulnerability or sadness. Controlled expressions of **anger**, however, were acceptable as signs of authority and masculinity
- ★ Be powerful and physically capable, with an inclination toward violence; **duelling culture** reinforced the idea of violence as an expression of masculinity
- ★ Protect and provide for their families; men were seen as the heads of households
- ★ Be aggressive in their sexuality
- ★ Be strong, rational, and respectable leaders

Remember that *Macbeth* is set in 11th-century Scotland, where violence and masculinity were closely connected. **Threats or challenges to a man's masculinity** were taken very seriously and required a response in order to maintain status.

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Why is masculinity a key theme in *Macbeth*?

Shakespeare has included the theme of masculinity for various reasons:

- ★ To challenge traditional ideas of masculinity as purely violent and dominant
- ★ To demonstrate that there is **no 'single' kind of masculinity**: for example, compare Macbeth with Macduff
- ★ To expose the dangers of linking manhood with aggression and cruelty
- ★ To highlight Jacobean beliefs about gender norms
- ★ To demonstrate how **toxic masculinity** can lead to tragedy

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Masculinity in *Macbeth*

Which characters in the play do or don't exhibit masculine traits? Why do you think so?

To me, Macbeth exhibits traditionally masculine traits at the start of the play because he is praised highly for his courage and valiance in battle. In eleventh-century Scotland, which was the play's setting, one's masculinity was determined by their military achievements. This is why Macbeth is awarded the title of Thane of Cawdor for killing Macdonwald in battle - in 'Macbeth', masculinity is often linked to violence.

Though she is not a man, Lady Macbeth also presents some traditionally masculine qualities in her competitive nature, appetite for violence, and domination in her relationship. This demonstrates that masculinity is not limited to just men - women often reinforce patriarchal masculinity.

Extract: Act 1 Scene 7

In this 'live lesson' recording, the play director and two RSC (Royal Shakespeare Company) actors playing Lady Macbeth and Macbeth discuss how best to stage the play. Watch the video and answer the questions.

Macbeth | Live Lesson | 2023 | Royal Shakespeare Company

1:55	**What is Lady and Macbeth's relationship like at this point in the play?**
4:00 - 7:30	**What tactics does Lady Macbeth use on Macbeth?**
13:12 - 16:51	**Watch the actors' first go at the scene. How well do think they performed these lines, and why?**
17:00 -19:54	**What are the actors told to do and why?**
19:54 - 22:56	**What did the actors do differently on their second performance? Which performance did you prefer?**

Image credits: Royal Shakespeare Company

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Extract: Act 1 Scene 7

You are now going to read an extract from Act 1 Scene 7.

At this point in the play Macbeth and Lady Macbeth are in conversation. Macbeth has just informed Lady Macbeth that he does not think they should kill Duncan.

As you read the extract, think about:

- ★ **What is happening** in the extract?
- ★ **Where** in the play can this extract be found?
- ★ **Why** is this extract a **crucial moment** in the play?
- ★ What **other parts of the play** could this extract link to?
- ★ What language and structural **techniques** have been used and why?
- ★ What **wider ideas** does this extract convey about masculinity?

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Close reading: Act 1 Scene 7

LADY MACBETH
Was the hope drunk
Wherein you dressed yourself? Hath it slept since?
And wakes it now, to look so green and pale
At what it did so freely? From this time
Such I account thy love. Art thou afeard
To be the same in thine own act and valor
As thou art in desire? Wouldst thou have that
Which thou esteem'st the ornament of life,
And live a coward in thine own esteem,
Letting "I dare not" wait upon "I would,"
Like the poor cat i' th' adage?

Mixed metaphor: hope is both drunk and something that Macbeth has worn (like clothing). She is asking whether his plan to kill Duncan was just drunken idealism

Metaphor compares Macbeth to a hungover man who regrets his drunkenness

LM **emasculates** Macbeth by using a series of **rhetorical questions** to question his bravery: the very essence of his manhood

LM **equates** action with bravery and therefore masculinity. According to her logic, because Macbeth cannot take action, he must be a coward, and not a true man

Hyperbolic metaphor for the crown of Scotland

Refers to a medieval **proverb** about a cat that wants to eat fish but refuses to get its feet wet. Suggests Macbeth is too **cautious** – and therefore not masculine enough

MACBETH
Prithee, peace: I dare do all that may become a man;
Who dares do more is none.

Modal verb 'may' suggests Macbeth is uncertain about the plan

Short line, breaking the **rhythm** of **iambic pentameter**

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Practice exam question

LADY MACBETH
Was the hope drunk
Wherein you dressed yourself?
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MACBETH
Prithee, peace: I dare do all that may become a man;
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Starting with this extract, write about how Shakespeare presents **masculinity** in the play. Write about:

- ★ How Shakespeare presents masculinity in this conversation
- ★ How Shakespeare presents masculinity in the play as a whole.

Now that we've read through the extract in detail, consult the practice exam question on the left and make notes on how Shakespeare presents masculinity in this conversation.

You might have said:

- ★ Lady Macbeth associates masculinity with **action, ambition and decisiveness**
- ★ On the other hand, Macbeth's idea of masculinity is **moral and restrained** - a real man knows right from wrong
- ★ Masculinity is an **unstable** concept because it is a **social construct** - the couple clearly disagree on what it means to be a man

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Key scenes

We also need to think about the **rest of the play**. Note down below **three to five key moments** in the play which involve the theme of masculinity.

Act 1 Scene 5: Lady Macbeth **renounces** her femininity

Act 1 Scene 7: Lady Macbeth **emasculates** Macbeth because he refuses to go through with the murder of King Duncan

Act 3 Scene 4: Lady Macbeth scolds Macbeth at the banquet for acting like a woman

Act 4 Scene 3: Macduff learns that his family have been slaughtered, and says he must '**feel it as a man**'

Act 3 Scene 1: Macbeth tells the two murderers that they will not be real men until they are ready to kill Banquo

Act 5 Scene 8: Ross says Young Siward died 'like a man' by fighting Macbeth

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Practice exam question

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Your essay should include three topic sentences - one to begin each paragraph. Using your knowledge of the **whole play**, note down your topic sentences below.

TS1	In this conversation, Lady Macbeth **weaponises** masculinity to shame Macbeth into murdering King Duncan.
TS2	Secondly,
TS3	Finally,

Practice exam question: peer review

In this conversation which closes the first act of *Macbeth*, Shakespeare presents Lady Macbeth as weaponising masculinity to manipulate and shame Macbeth into murdering King Duncan. Sensing that Macbeth is faltering in his determination, Lady Macbeth employs a variety of tactics to have him reconsider his doubts. She emasculates him through a series of rhetorical questions, such as 'Art thou afeard,' implying that fear makes him weak and unmanly. Her manipulative logic equates masculinity with courage and action, insinuating he would be a 'coward', and therefore not a true man, if he did not kill Duncan. In eleventh-century Scotland, which was under a feudal system, male identity was centred around physical and military achievements. Macbeth's promotion to 'thane' reflects a feudal system which valorised traditional, aggressive masculinity. Lady Macbeth's tactics would have therefore humiliated Macbeth, in directly undermining his masculine identity as a soldier and high-ranking official. Her mocking comparison to 'the poor cat i' th' adage' further humiliates him, implying he desires the rewards of kingship but lacks the bravery to act. In contrast, Macbeth's understanding of masculinity is moral and restrained, as he states, 'I dare do all that may become a man'. However, Lady Macbeth's relentless taunting undermines this view, showing how easily masculinity can be manipulated as a social construct. Shakespeare therefore presents masculinity in this conversation as a means of psychological control; Lady Macbeth cleverly exploits social expectations of masculinity to pressure Macbeth into committing regicide.

Review the following paragraph that an English student has written. Then highlight:

- ★ Context (AO3) in yellow
- ★ Evidence (AO2) in green
- ★ Personal argument (AO1) in blue
- ★ Linking words (AO4) in pink

What level (/9) would you give this paragraph and why?

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Practice exam question: detailed feedback

In this conversation which closes the first act of *Macbeth*, **Shakespeare presents Lady Macbeth as weaponising masculinity to manipulate and shame Macbeth into murdering King Duncan**. Sensing that Macbeth is faltering in his determination, Lady Macbeth employs a variety of tactics to have him reconsider his doubts. She emasculates him through a series of rhetorical questions, such as '**Art thou afeard**,' **implying that fear makes him weak and unmanly**. **Her manipulative logic equates masculinity with courage and action, insinuating he would be a 'coward', and therefore not a true man, if he did not kill Duncan**. In eleventh-century Scotland, which was under a feudal system, male identity was centred around physical and military achievements. Macbeth's promotion to 'thane' reflects a feudal system which valorised traditional, aggressive masculinity. Lady Macbeth's tactic would have therefore humiliated Macbeth, in directly undermining his masculine identity as a soldier and high-ranking official. Her mocking comparison to 'the poor cat i' th' adage' further humiliates him, implying he desires the rewards of kingship but lacks the bravery to act. In contrast, Macbeth's understanding of masculinity is moral and restrained, as he states, 'I dare do all that may become a man'. However, Lady Macbeth's relentless taunting undermines this view, showing how easily masculinity can be manipulated as a social construct. Shakespeare therefore presents masculinity in this conversation as a means of psychological control; Lady Macbeth cleverly exploits social expectations of masculinity to pressure Macbeth into committing regicide.

- ★ This is a good paragraph because it does all the key things examiners are looking for, but in a clear and organised way.
- ★ First, it starts with a clear point that **answers the question straight away**.
- ★ The student then uses **short quotations** that directly engage with the question.
- ★ They **zoom** into specific words and analyse their meanings and effects.

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Practice exam question: detailed feedback

In this conversation which closes the first act of *Macbeth*, Shakespeare presents Lady Macbeth as weaponising masculinity to manipulate and shame Macbeth into murdering King Duncan. Sensing that Macbeth is faltering in his determination, Lady Macbeth employs a variety of tactics to have him reconsider his doubts. She emasculates him through a series of rhetorical questions, such as 'Art thou afeard,' implying that fear makes him weak and unmanly. **Her manipulative logic equates masculinity with courage and action**, insinuating he would be a 'coward', and therefore not a true man, if he did not kill Duncan. **In eleventh-century Scotland, which was under a feudal system, male identity was centred around physical and military achievements**. Macbeth's promotion to 'thane' reflects a feudal system which valorised traditional, aggressive masculinity. **Lady Macbeth's tactic would have therefore humiliated Macbeth, in directly undermining his masculine identity** as a soldier and high-ranking official. Her mocking comparison to 'the poor cat i' th' adage' further humiliates him, implying he desires the rewards of kingship but lacks the bravery to act. In contrast, Macbeth's understanding of masculinity is moral and restrained, as he states, 'I dare do all that may become a man'. However, Lady Macbeth's relentless taunting undermines this view, showing how easily masculinity can be manipulated as a social construct. Shakespeare therefore presents masculinity in this conversation as a means of psychological control; Lady Macbeth cleverly exploits social expectations of masculinity to pressure Macbeth into committing regicide.

- ★ The student **links all arguments back** to masculinity. They connect every bit of analysis to how Lady Macbeth is attacking Macbeth's masculinity.
- ★ This **keeps their paragraph focused** and stops it from going off track.
- ★ The student also includes **context** in a simple but relevant way. They explain that during the 11th century, men were expected to be brave soldiers, and therefore Macbeth would have felt even more insulted by Lady Macbeth's attacks.

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Practice exam question: detailed feedback

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- ★ The student reaches a level 8/9 by introducing **contrast** into their argument.

  Why do you think this is the case?

- ★ Finally, the ending sums everything up clearly, saying that masculinity is used as a way to control Macbeth.
- ★ The conclusion helps to bring all the student's ideas together and shows the examiner they've answered the question fully.

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Practice exam question: writing

Now that you've seen a model answer, it's your turn to write one **essay paragraph** in the box below.